

DIGITAL LITERACY CASE STUDY REPORT

Course Code: CSE0001

Course Title: Digital Literacy

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Section A: Establish the Context

The Gap Between Tool Usage and System Understanding

In the modern digital era, there is a common misconception that being able to navigate digital interfaces is synonymous with being digitally literate. This case study highlights a profound "Gap" between **Digital Participation** and **Digital Literacy**. While students are increasingly comfortable using tools like Canva, Prezi, or Google Docs, they often operate these systems without a fundamental understanding of their underlying mechanisms.

As seen in Arjun's journey, participation is merely the act of operating a tool—such as selecting a template or clicking a link. In contrast, true literacy involves understanding the ethical implications, security risks, and long-term responsibilities that come with those actions. Widespread access to user-friendly platforms has created an **illusion of digital competence**. A student may produce a visually stunning presentation, but if they do not understand copyright laws, data privacy, or the psychological tactics of cybercriminals, they remain digitally vulnerable despite their technical activity.

Section B: Digital Identity and Ethics

Position: *Building a digital presence offers significant professional opportunities, but these benefits are currently outweighed by ethical risks such as performative behavior and the lack of digital permanence awareness.*

- **Equal Opportunity:** Platforms like LinkedIn and GitHub theoretically democratize the professional world by allowing students from any background to showcase their work to global recruiters.
- **The Visibility Trap:** However, as Arjun's case demonstrates, these platforms often reward **visibility over competence**. Students feel pressured to maintain an "active" status, often leading them to post incomplete projects or surface-level content just to stay relevant in the algorithm.

- **Ethics of Misrepresentation:** Exaggerating skills or presenting "lab-only" code as expert knowledge is a common but unethical practice. This fabrication pollutes the integrity of the professional ecosystem, making it harder for recruiters to find genuine talent.
 - **Digital Permanence:** Students often forget that the internet is a **permanent record**. Inconsistencies or poorly presented work from early college years can resurface later, damaging professional reputations before a career has even begun.
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Section C: Collaboration vs. Misuse

Digital collaboration platforms like Google Workspace and shared coding environments have revolutionized how we work, but they also present a challenge to individual accountability.

- **The Efficiency Argument:** These tools allow for seamless asynchronous work, removing geographical and scheduling barriers.
 - **The Reality of Misuse:** In practice, digital collaboration often facilitates **"Free-Riding"**. Because effort is less visible in a polished final document, one student may perform the majority of the cognitive work while others contribute only surface-level formatting or copied content.
 - **The Ethical Boundary:** The line between collaboration and academic dishonesty is crossed when a student relies on the group's output without achieving a personal understanding of the material. Effective digital collaboration must be paired with individual accountability checks, such as vivas, to ensure the learning objective is met rather than just the task.
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Section D: Cyber Awareness and Responsibility

The paradox of cybersecurity is that **awareness does not guarantee safe behavior**. Arjun was aware of phishing, yet he fell victim to it because the attack bypassed his knowledge and targeted his emotions.

- **Psychology of the Attack:** Cybercriminals utilize "Urgency" and "Aspiration" to cloud a user's judgment. By creating a time-sensitive internship offer, they force a student into an "automatic" response state where they stop verifying the source.
 - **Shared Responsibility:** Protecting oneself is an individual duty, but platforms and institutions must also be held accountable. We need safer system designs that flag suspicious links more effectively and educational programs that focus on building **habits**—like verifying sender addresses—rather than just memorizing facts.
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Section E: Communication and Digital Etiquette

Professional communication is a distinct skill that many students fail to apply because of their **instant messaging habits**.

- **The Habit Overlap:** In casual chats, speed and brevity are valued. When these habits carry over to formal emails, as seen with Arjun's abrupt request to his professor, they are perceived as disrespectful and unprofessional.
 - **The Signaling Effect:** A professional email is a signal of respect and attention to detail. Poor communication can lead to a loss of opportunity, as authoritative figures are less likely to support students who appear transactional or careless in their interactions.
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Section F: Reflection

Initially, I believed digital literacy was simply the ability to operate complex software and navigate online platforms. However, this case study has shifted my perspective toward **responsible decision-making**. I realized that I, like Arjun, have sometimes operated on "autopilot," prioritizing visibility and speed over authenticity and verification. My primary takeaway is that digital safety and professionalism are **active habits**, not passive traits. Moving forward, I will commit to a "Pause and Verify" approach, ensuring that my digital footprint is a true and safe representation of my professional identity.